

Accuse and blame

Learner workbook

Distinguish an allegation from an assignment of responsibility.

Understand the distinction

Accuse someone of something means say that the person did something wrong: accuse someone of lying. Blame someone for something assigns responsibility: blame the supplier for a delay.

An accusation is a claim, not proof. Use alleged, said, or according to when reporting an unestablished claim. In a practical discussion, describing an observed problem and asking for an explanation can be more useful than assigning blame.

Compare the patterns

ACCUSE OF

They accused him of sharing the file.

They claimed he did something wrong.

BLAME FOR

They blamed the delay on a missed delivery.

This assigns a cause.

OBSERVE

The file arrived after the deadline.

This states an observable event.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: She accused him ___ copying.

2. Complete: They blamed me ___ the mistake.

3. Does was accused of prove that someone did it?

Use it in your own life

Rewrite an accusation as a factual observation and a question.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. of

The pattern is accuse someone of something.

2. for

Use blame someone for something.

3. No. It reports an allegation.

Keep the distinction between a claim and an established fact.

One possible response

The report arrived after the deadline. What caused the delay?

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-24.html